



team's quest for its inaugural title on March 1.

While acknowledging the heightened pressure, Sethpal cites his team's successful track record against the playoff opponent, the Gujarat Giants, this season.

"We cannot afford to take risks that we could take in league matches. We are very confident; we've defeated the Gujarat Giants twice in the league stage. It is going to be a tough match, but we're ready for the challenge," says Sethpal, who idolises Gujarat's captain Fazel Atrachali.

Coach's guidance

Coming from Bapulua village in Haryana, Sethpal was exposed to the sport of Kabaddi during his childhood. He was motivated by the local Kabaddi star Nitin Rawal, who is also a member of the Bengal Warriors and the Indian Kabaddi team.

Sethpal attributes his Kabaddi career's foundation to his village

coach, Pramod Rawal, but acknowledges his current coach, Manpreet Singh, for his recent success.

"Coach Sir provides individual guidance, offering different strategies for each match and having backup plans in case of unforeseen circumstances. He also encourages us to express ourselves on the mat," he opines. The defender also values the leadership of his captain and fellow Haryana lad, Jaideep Dahiya. Their long-standing bond allows them to anticipate each other's moves seamlessly. "I've been playing with Jaideep since 2018. I know when he's

Making inroads: Rahul Sethpal (in blue) in action against Telugu Titans' Pawan Sehrawat. PKL

going to pounce on a raider. As a defensive unit, we know when someone is enticing a raider, and the others get alert to make a move. We are getting a lot of tackle points, and that's because of the bonding and understanding," he concludes.

With frailties in its raiding unit, the Steelers will bank on their in-form defence to thrust themselves towards the centre of the podium, and Sethpal has to bring his best effort in that quest.

« Sethpal carefully analyses the movements of his opponent raiders and capitalises on their weaknesses »